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FREE GUIDE FOR HOME SERVICE OWNERS

# THE BAD REVIEW SURVIVAL GUIDE

What one 1-star review really does to your rating, how many 5-stars it takes to recover, and exactly what to say back.

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# ONE BAD REVIEW WON'T SINK YOU. A THIN REVIEW COUNT WILL.

Every contractor gets one eventually. A customer has a bad day, a job runs late, somebody misreads the quote. The question isn't whether it happens. It's how much it hurts when it does.

The short answer: one 1-star review can knock a small business from a 4.8 down to a 4.5. The same review barely moves a business with 100 reviews. The difference isn't the review. It's how many reviews are standing next to it.

## HOW GOOGLE FIGURES YOUR RATING

Google's help page for business owners says your score is the average of all the ratings published on Google for your business, and that an updated score can take up to two weeks to show. Google doesn't spell out exactly how it rounds, so a simple average rounded to one decimal is a close approximation.

**Rating = total stars ÷ number of reviews**

Every review is one vote. That makes your review count your shock absorber.

### One 1-star review, four different businesses

| Starting point | After one 1-star | Exact average | What shows on Google |
|---|---|---|---|
| 10 reviews, all 5-star (5.0) | 51 ÷ 11 | 4.636 | **4.6** |
| 100 reviews, all 5-star (5.0) | 501 ÷ 101 | 4.960 | **5.0** |
| 10 reviews averaging 4.8 | 49 ÷ 11 | 4.4545 | **4.5** |
| 100 reviews averaging 4.8 | 481 ÷ 101 | 4.762 | **4.8** |

Same customer, same complaint, very different damage. The 10-review business lost four tenths of a star. The 100-review business lost nothing you can see.

> **Why tenths of a star matter:** BrightLocal's 2026 consumer survey found that 31% of consumers will only use a business rated 4.5 stars or higher, 68% will only use a business with 4 stars or more, and negative reviews deter 77% of consumers from using a business.

# HOW MANY 5-STARS IT TAKES TO RECOVER

Every "Google review calculator" online runs this one formula. Here it is so you can do it on your phone.

$$\text{New 5-stars needed} \geq (T \times N - S) \div (5 - T)$$

**T** = the rating you want, **N** = how many reviews you have now, **S** = your total stars now. Round up.

**Example:** 49 stars across 11 reviews (showing 4.5). Back to a true 4.8?
4.8 × 11 = 52.8 → 52.8 − 49 = 3.8 → 3.8 ÷ 0.2 = **19 five-star reviews**.
Check: 49 + (19 × 5) = 144 stars ÷ 30 reviews = 4.8.

Nineteen reviews to undo one bad day. That's the real cost of a thin review count. And getting back to a displayed 5.0 after a 1-star with 10 perfect reviews takes 69 more 5-stars. Most owners are better off aiming for a strong 4.8 or 4.9. BrightLocal found only 10% of consumers require 5 stars.

# WHAT TO DO THE DAY A 1-STAR SHOWS UP

### 1. Reply once, calmly, in public

Wait until you've cooled off. Thank them, own what's yours, and offer to fix it offline with a name and a number. Future customers read your reply right under the review.

**Example review (Mike):** "Showed up two hours late and nobody called. Work was fine but I wasted my morning."

**Good reply:** "Mike, I'm sorry we ran late and didn't call ahead. That's on us. I'd like to make it right. Please call me directly at the shop. — Rob, owner"

**Bad reply:** "This customer never paid their invoice and is lying."

Arguing in public, or sharing private details, only makes the next homeowner side with them.

### 2. Report it only if it really breaks Google's rules

Fake reviews, reviews from people who were never customers, and spam can be flagged. A review you simply disagree with usually won't come down. Never threaten anyone over a review: the FTC's rule bars using groundless legal threats or intimidation to get reviews removed.

### 3. Keep asking every customer

This is the real fix. Ask every customer the same way, soon after the job, by text or email with a direct link. Don't only ask the ones you think are happy. Google's policies don't allow selectively asking for positive reviews, and a steady flow of honest reviews is what absorbs the occasional bad one.

> **Free tool:** make your one-tap review link and a printable QR code at reviiewco.com/tools/google-review-link-generator. No signup, nothing stored.

### 4. Build the cushion before you need it

If you have fewer than 20 or so reviews, every one carries a lot of weight. Your best protection against the next bad review is the 30 good ones that land before it.

# SOURCES


- BrightLocal, Local Consumer Review Survey 2026: brightlocal.com/research/local-consumer-review-survey
- Google Business Profile Help, Scoring ratings for local places: support.google.com/business/answer/4801187
- Google Maps user contributed content policy: support.google.com/contributionpolicy/answer/7400114
- FTC final rule banning fake reviews and testimonials (Aug 2024): ftc.gov
- Full article: reviiewco.com/blog/how-much-does-one-bad-review-hurt

DO IT YOURSELF, OR HAND IT OFF

# THAT'S THE WHOLE PLAYBOOK.

Everything above works, and you can do every bit of it yourself. Most owners we talk to don't have the time, because they're out doing the work. That's exactly what ReviiewCo is for.

### Do it yourself

- Ask every customer, every job, the same way
- Work your old customer list in steady batches
- Reply to every review within a few days
- Keep it going when the schedule gets busy

### Or we do it for you

- A friendly text after every job, plus up to two reminders
- Your past-customer list worked for you
- A reply to every review, in your voice
- Missed-Call-Text Back included

**$297/month. No contract. No setup fee.**

Guarantee: at least 10 new Google reviews in 30 days when you send us a list of 300+ past customers, or every dollar back. The 30 days start once we have your list and access to your Google profile.

**Talk it through with Rob (30 min, no pressure)**
reviiewco.com/book

**Get started**
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**Call or text, answered 24/7**
864-528-1909

General information, not legal advice. Example names, reviews and texts are illustrations, not real customers.